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Chapter 1

A person in society

Of course, everyone becomes a person in society: we cannot stop this. And, so, why write a book about learning to be a person in society? Perhaps this is an obvious question, but the answer is much more difficult – it does not just happen by birth or by chance; we actually learn to become the people we are. I learn to be me! You learn to be you! But we do not just learn to be us during our schooling. Learning is much broader than education – learning is a lifelong process and we are the result of our own learning. It is this that we are going to try to understand in this book. And, so, in this first chapter we are going to examine some of the fundamental concepts underlying this complex social process, and we will see that this is both a psychological and a sociological study of learning, although it must necessarily incorporate philosophical aspects since learning is, in one sense, a humanistic process. The approach of any one discipline to learning is insufficient for our understanding of learning to be a person in society but we will rely very heavily on psychological studies, especially of early childhood.

This first chapter seeks to clarify the concepts and examine the implications of our thinking – it has three parts: the first part looks at the concept of the person, the second at society and the third at the person in society.

Part 1: The concept of the person

In the contemporary world, one which has experienced the genetic revolution in the past quarter of a century, we do well to ask ‘What is the person?’, ‘What makes us human?’. It is incontrovertible that we human beings are members of the ape family – DNA research has demonstrated just how much we are members of this family, and so the question is ‘What makes us human?’. Are we only great apes (Dunbar, 2007)? Dunbar, amongst many others, argues that the fundamental difference is ‘the theory of mind’ – ‘the capacity to imagine another individual’s mind states’ (Dunbar, 2007: 40). First-order intentionality is the term used to cover these mind states, and Dunbar (ibid.: 41) suggests that there is no evidence to suggest that any animals apart from chimpanzees (and perhaps other of the great apes) have a theory of mind. If they do so, he suggests that the level to which they have evolved is about the same level as children aged four or five years. But human beings have more sophisticated levels of intentionality; the human mind, he suggests, has been in existence for only about 200,000 years – a short time when we consider that our last common ancestor with the apes probably lived about five and a half million years ago. This is a very similar position to that taken by Tomasello (1999: 55), who writes:

> We have at most only 6 million years, but more likely only one-quarter of a million years, to create uniquely human cognition, and this is simply not sufficient, under any plausible evolutionary scenario, for genetic variation and natural selection to have created many different and independent uniquely human modules.

Tomasello (ibid.: 54) argues that human cultural inheritance rests on twin pillars:

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> sociogenesis, by means of which most cultural artefacts and practices are created, and cultural learning, by means of which these creations and the human intentions and perspectives that lie behind them are internalized by developing youngsters.

And so we can see that from within an evolutionary framework, it is still meaningful to enquire about the nature of personhood since we may locate ourselves as being at the pinnacle of the process of evolution whilst still acknowledging that we are by our genetic inheritance members of the ape family, but discussion about the nature of the person has to leave the evolutionary perspective and begin to look at the phenomenon from a more humanistic perspective.

The person, like society, has a common-sense usage, but in order to clarify our thinking we do need to explore the several meanings of the term. It is perhaps significant that the term 'person' does not occur in the index of Rogers' (1961) classic *On Becoming a Person*, although he does discuss 'personal constructs' and has a whole section on the philosophy of the person from a therapist's perception. This illustrates the position from which Rogers is approaching this topic and, although therapy throws considerable light on the subject, not all individuals become persons as a result of therapy. But we will also find a lot more from Rogers in his *Freedom to Learn* studies (Rogers, 1983; Rogers and Freiberg, 1994); even here his main focus is therapeutic although he claims that the goal of learning and therapy is to be 'a fully functioning person'. This is clearly the end-product of his therapeutic process, but it is also the aim of many psychological studies and policy statements on learning. Other psychologists have tried in a variety of ways to capture the complexity of becoming a fully functioning person: for instance, Maslow's (1968) famous hierarchy of needs – physiological, safety, love and belonging, self-esteem and self-actualisation – illustrates this position.

McAdams' (2001) full study of the person, to which we will make reference from time to time throughout this book, tells us more about the personality traits and characteristics than it does about the concept of the person itself. Haslam's (2007) introduction to personality is also referred to throughout this book. Apter (1989) suggests that the person has distinctness, continuity and autonomy. MacMurray (1979 [1961]: 27), however, suggests that 'the term "person" fulfils the same function from the standpoint of the agent as the term "self" does in traditional philosophy, which thinks from the standpoint of the subject'. But we do use the word in a variety of different ways, as *Collins English Dictionary* shows:

- an individual human being;
- the body of a human being, e.g. 'on his/her person';
- a grammatical category, e.g. singular or plural;
- an individual having certain rights and obligations in law;
- a being characterised by personality, consciousness, rationality, morality and self-awareness;
- a role or guise;
- actually present, e.g. in person.

Almost all of these usages are open to considerable debate, and we will return to these shortly. However, when we consult a philosophical dictionary (Speake, 1984) we are confronted with a short discussion which points us to Locke's work. Locke wrote that a person is:

> A thinking intelligent being that has reason and reflection and can consider itself as itself, the same thinking thing in different times and places; which it does only by that consciousness which is inseparable from thinking and, as it seems to me, essential to it: it is impossible for anyone to perceive without perceiving that he does perceive. When we see, hear, small, taste, feel meditate or will anything, we know that we do so. Thus it is always to our present

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> sensations and perceptions, and by this everyone is to himself that which he calls a *self*: it is not being considered in this case whether the same *self* be continued in the same or diverse substances.
>
> (Locke, 1947: 180, italics in original)

Immediately we are confronted with the concept of 'self' here. This is a term to which we will return but, following MacMurray, I see 'self' as the nearest equivalent to the person in relation to this study. One other feature that emerges immediately is that the self may be 'of the mind' but whether it is of 'the brain' is more controversial. Indeed, we have to note immediately that there is a controversy about the nature of the person as body and mind, in which the self is a construct of the mind, and so on. It is an unresolved debate, but the position adopted here is that the self is learned, as is the mind, and that there is a very complex relationship between body/brain and mind. Indeed, I agree with Feser (2006: 211) when he concludes that 'Descartes' basic contention that the mind is irreducible to the brain or body has not been refuted'. But we can at least begin to see that even a simple term such as 'person' is open to much more debate than is apparent on the surface.

It is significant in all these formulations that the ability to do – to act, create and relate – is hardly present in this discussion although many contemporary scholars see this at the heart of our humanity. Arendt (1958) opens her classic work on the human condition by discussing *viva activa*, in which she says there are three dimensions – labour, work and action. Labour is the basic human condition – it is the bodily processes; work corresponds to the unnaturalness of the human condition – it is the artificial world of production; action is the activity that goes on between people, especially the political elements that enable people to live together – it is relating. In a similar way, Archer (2000: 154–90) sees the practical as pivotal in her arguments about being human. Doing is at the heart of being human, but creating is the process of building our world and making it a better place for us all to live: we all need to become experts in doing and creating – we should not be content with mere competencies – in our contribution to the world. Consequently, we need to include this dimension in any understanding that we have of the person – the ego.

For the moment let us accept that the person is an individual capable of doing, thinking and sensing in a wide variety of ways. I will return to this discussion at the end of this work. However, the person is not fully formed at birth – what I am arguing here is that the person is learned in the process of human living and, therefore, the self only emerges out of this process and so unlike many experientialists the self is a problematic in this process. Newman (2008: 288) comments that 'most experiential learning starts with the self as a given' and, although his assertion might have some validity, it is not true for all experiential learning theorists and so it is a pity that he did not widen the scope of his investigation and start with consciousness. But there is another problem: most experiential learning theories start with the adult whereas, in this book, we start with the fetus! The person is individual, and it is important from the outset of this study to recognise that the Enlightenment focused on the individual to such an extent that it became central to a great deal of our thinking; however, in this contemporary society, modernity is regarded being as flawed (Gray, 1995; Jarvis, 2008) and so the focus of our study can no longer be on the isolated individual because the person lives in relationship. Individuals emerge out of relationship.

Part 2: The concept of society

Margaret Thatcher, when she was prime minister of the UK, famously exclaimed that 'there is no such thing as society'. Of course, if she was looking for an empirical reality, such as a house, or even a world, then she was perfectly correct. But there are many things that cannot be reified, such as light, a black hole, and so on. Society is another such concept: it cannot be reified but that does not mean that it does not exist, and so it is now necessary for us to explore the

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complexities of this common concept in precisely the same way as we have for person. This will form the first part of this section and in the second we will examine the concept of culture, which has been regarded in the past as something that is society-wide.

Society

Once more *Collins English Dictionary* provides a starting point:

- the totality of relationships among organised groups of human beings or animals;
- a system of human organisation generating distinctive cultural patterns and institutions;
- a system of human beings with reference to its social and economic organisation;
- those with whom one has companionship;
- an organised group of people associating for some specific purpose;
- a privileged class of people;
- the social life of such a privileged class;
- companionship;
- a small community of plants within a larger association.

These are very general descriptions of forms of human relationship and organisation. A sociological dictionary suggests that sociologists, while accepting the above definitions, also treat it as in some ways equivalent to the nation state (Abercrombie *et al*., 2000), which in the light of globalisation and other social processes has ceased to be a simple, single political entity. Globalisation is a theme that has occupied many books (Jarvis, 2007a) but it is not the processes of recent globalisation or global culture that are the major issues for our purposes: it is the nature of the culture of a society that is significant, and we can see that there is now no ‘pure’ single racial or ethnic culture even if there was in the past. We are confronted with a global society through the media, and in most areas in which we live there are representatives of a number of ethnic groups, so that the more general dictionary definitions might reflect the reality of the society in which many, if not most, people live. It is a multicultural society and in the West it is a society that is dominated by the culture of modernity.

Although the nation state has lost the idea of sovereign independence, governments still have certain forms of jurisdiction over specific territories, and these countries are organised regionally and locally; they have forms of governance over the population irrespective of the different people’s ethnic origins. In this sense, society is now separated from the idea of a single culture and people live in their own ‘life-worlds’, which is the term some sociologists prefer to convey the idea of the person in society; however, before we discuss this idea we need to look at the concept of culture.

Culture

Like the first two concepts that we have examined, culture is a word common to everyday life and so once again we will start by looking at *Collins English Dictionary’s* definitions:

- the total of the inherited ideas, beliefs, values and knowledge, which constitutes the shared basis of social action;
- the shared traditions which are transmitted and reinforced by members of a social group;
- a particular civilisation;
- the artistic and social pursuits, expressions and tastes valued by a society;
- the enlightenment or refinement resulting from these pursuits;

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- the cultivation of plants;
- the experimental growth of micro-organisms …

(There are several other usages given in the dictionary – all referring to topics that do not concern this study, such as agriculture.)

Once again, this is not a reifiable concept although there is a tendency to treat it as a thing. It is about practices and beliefs and values, and so on. When we turn to the sociological dictionary (Abercrombie *et al*., 2000) we find a more complex discussion, but one essential to our study. Culture is:

- contrasted with the biological – the non-biological aspects of human society;
- contrasted with nature – it is to do with civilisation rather than barbarism;
- contrasted with structure – it is the social cement which keeps the institutions of society intact;
- contrasted with the material – it is the realm of beliefs etc. influenced by society's substructure;
- a way of life – each society had a common culture;
- contrasts between ways of life – high and popular culture, with the former being elitist.

The widest of these definitions contrasts culture to the biological and so we will adopt this wide definition here – culture is 'the word we give to … (the) world of images, stories, objects and ways of acting to which we have recourse in our struggle to exist. But culture is not what determines the acting, or the need to act. These are existential imperatives' (Jackson, 2005: 103). The obvious point to make here is that the person is a combination of these broad perspectives – both biological and cultural – and the study of both is important for us if we are to begin to understand human learning. Gehlen (1988: 29) reached a similar conclusion from an anthropological perspective years earlier when he wrote (italics in original):

> In order to survive, he [humankind] must master and recreate nature, and for this reason man must *experience* the world. He acts because he is unspecialized and deprived of a natural environment to which he is adapted. The epitome of nature restructured to serve his needs is called *culture* and the culture world is the human world … Culture, therefore, is 'second nature' – man's restructured nature.

But unlike the animals, humans may have minimal instincts although they have many predispositions and inclinations as a result of their evolution and their learning in the womb and so they have to learn this second nature and pass it on from generation to generation, so that children's education is often seen as transmitting the most worthwhile knowledge from one generation to the succeeding one. In this sense, education is 'from above' since the dominant forces in the older generation decide what should be included in the curriculum – one way of viewing curriculum is that it is a selection from culture. However, culture does not remain a static phenomenon, and Wexler (2006: 185) suggests historically culture would have remained rudimentary until the advent of a developed language. Tomasello (1999: 5) has argued:

> Basically none of the most complex human artefacts or practices – including tool industries, symbolic communication, and social institutions – were invented once and for all at a single moment by any one individual or group of individuals. Rather, what happened was that some individual or group first invented a primitive version of the artefact or practice, and then some later user or users made a modification or 'improvement,' that others then

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> adopted perhaps without change for many generations, at which point some other individual or group of individuals made another modification, which was then learned and used by others, and so on over historical time in what has sometimes been dubbed 'the ratchet effect'.

Hence, culture has undergone a process of cumulative evolution but, although it differs between East and West, it remains all the knowledge, skills, attitudes, beliefs, values and emotions that we, as human beings, have added to our biological base and which we externalise as a result of our learning. Culture is a social phenomenon; it is what we as a society, or a people, share and which enables us to live as society. In order for a society to survive, it is necessary that we should each learn our own culture and appreciate the cultures of others. Learning, then, becomes necessary for the survival of societies and in the process we, as human beings, learn to be.

But culture differs from country to country, although some of the main cultural differences are between those which stem from the Judeo-Greek–European heritage countries, i.e. Western civilisation, and those that emanate from Confucian heritage countries, i.e. Eastern civilisation. Nisbett (2003: xv) notes that before he started his studies into comparative cultures he had assumed universality and hard-wiring of the brain, and so he was very surprised when there were major differences between countries and that individuals could be trained: his studies led to the significant conclusion: 'Human cognition is not everywhere the same' (ibid.: xvii) and these cultural groupings have significant differences. This conclusion is also echoed by Donald (2001: 274), when he suggests that language 'is a collective product and must have evolved as a group adaptation in the context of mimetic, expressive culture'. Such conclusions are fundamentally significant for learning theory.

Culture, then, is society-wide or at least social group- or ethnic group-wide, so that we can talk of British culture, American culture, Chinese culture, and so on, but they are no longer 'pure' because as a result of migration, the media, travel, and so on, the cultures of the world are dissipated and fused together in different ways in different parts of each country. Globalisation and rapid social change have affected the nature of society, and most societies are now multicultural. We all live in multicultural life-worlds that are gradually reflecting the locality, so that there is a certain myth about the unity of culture, which is the danger of reification to which we alluded above. Archer (1988) calls this the myth of cultural integration, and she goes on to show why she considers it a myth, although we may individually and subjectively integrate those cultures to which we are exposed through our learning processes – but we integrate them into our own biographies. We are aware of the fact that because of industrialisation, globalisation, migration, and so on, cultural homogeneity is probably restricted to pre-industrial peoples and small rural communities. Consequently, a number of different cultures exist in most urban societies in the West that are now regarded as multicultural and this phenomenon is exacerbated by the media. This might well result in some persons not acquiring the same sense of security, sense of community membership and self-identity as people did in previous generations, which, in turn, has given rise to identity crisis, what Giddens (1991) refers to as 'existential anxiety'.

It is also necessary to recognise that within complex societies there are different lifestyles, patterns of social living, organisations and so on, so that it is common practice to refer to the cultures of subgroups or sections of society as subcultures. Consequently, we can talk of the subculture of the school or the subculture of the work organisation, and so on, and now we can begin to see why sociologists have so many different perspectives on culture.

Part 3: The person in society

People no longer live in a single cultural society: they live in life-worlds which consist of a unique combination of cultural practices, depending on where people live and on their social position – amongst other things. Society is a

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combination of systems and life-worlds and the life-world is multicultural. In his discussions of the life-world, Habermas (1987: 117, italics in original) suggests that:

> No matter whether one starts with Mead from basic concepts of social interaction or with Durkheim from basic concepts of collective representation, in either case society is conceived from the perspective of acting subjects as the *lifeworld of the social group*. In contrast, from the observer's perspective as someone not involved society can be conceived only as a *system of actions* such that each action has a functional significance according to its contribution to the maintenance of the system.

Habermas argues that societies can be conceived as both system and life-worlds, but from the learners' perspective we can take the first part of this quote although we would want to add that the life-world and the society are not the same phenomenon. Society consists of many overlapping and intersecting life-worlds and we all construct our own life-worlds.

> The life-world is something to be mastered according to my particular interests. I project my plans into the life-world, and it resists the realization of my goals, in terms of which some things become feasible to me and others do not. From the outset, however, I find in my life-world fellow men who appear not merely as organisms but rather as bodies endowed with consciousness, as men 'like me'. A fellow-man's behaviour is not, if you will, a spatiotemporal event, but rather action 'like mine'.
>
> (Schutz and Luckmann, 1974: 15)

Our life-worlds are about practical living in the everyday and so our learning is about action in a pragmatic manner in order to achieve certain goals and behaviours. In this sense, most of our everyday learning is action learning – learning theoretical knowledge occurs at specified times, such as attending educational institutions, devoting time to reading and writing, and so on: it is about primary rather than secondary experience. For the most part we are dealing with practical knowledge and utilising our own experience (remembered biographical learning – we will return to the topic of experience in Chapter 5), and so it is not hard to see why the learning of the elders was in bygone generations regarded as wisdom. Our life-world is one with which we are familiar and so our behaviour can be taken for granted. As Schutz and Luckmann (ibid.: 7) write:

> I trust that the world as it has been known by me up until now will continue further and that consequently the stock of knowledge obtained from my fellow-men and formed from my own experiences will continue to preserve its fundamental validity … From this assumption follows the further one: that I can repeat my past successful acts. So long as the structure of the world can be taken as constant, as long as my previous experience is valid, my ability to act upon the world in this and that manner remains in principle preserved. As Husserl has shown, the further ideality of the 'I can always do it again' is developed correlative of the ideality of the 'and so forth'.

In a sense, we are 'at home' in our life-world and we learn to take pleasure in it: we can take our world for granted and it is perceived to be true because we are in harmony with it and our internal and external worlds are congruent and we are also at one with the individuals in our life-world – our personal community, as it were. There is a sense of unity and harmony – solidarity, if you like. But as we develop this personal community changes: as we go through our various socialisation processes, so our horizons change and expand. Our life-world is not a static phenomenon and is dependent upon our own biography and our own learning. Our life-world is dependent upon our use of appropriate language and culture, and our own learning and as we change from one situation to another, so we find we move from one domain to another. As Habermas (1987: 125) puts it:

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> Participants find the relations between the objective, social and subjective worlds already preinterpreted. When they go beyond the horizon of a given situation, they cannot step into a void; they find themselves right away in another, now actualized, yet *preinterpreted* domain of what is culturally taken for granted. In everyday communicative practice there are no completely unfamiliar situations. Every new situation appears in a lifeworld composed of a cultural stock of knowledge that is 'always already' familiar.

In these familiar situations, we learn to fit in and we adjust our behaviour accordingly in relationship to those others with whom we interact and, as we have already pointed out, there is often an element of power in this interaction. This adjustment is a form of learning – incidental and often unintended and unrecognised as learning, since we are involved in imitation of others in the life-world, trial and error and discovery learning when we cannot copy others, and so on. Additionally, we recognise that our subjective life-world is actually an intersubjective one, and for as long as we function within familiar territory we can take our world for granted – that is habitualise it – and we can share the meanings we give situations with those with whom we interact, but we may not always agree with each other although we will understand from where each is coming.

It is clear that we live in life-worlds which are social and so we are faced with the question of individuality – a concept with which a great deal of thinking in the West has started. Individuality was not a new concept at the time of the Enlightenment and was probably first discussed in the writings of the Hebrew prophet, Jeremiah, in the seventh century before Christ when he wrote about individual responsibility:

> The fathers have eaten sour grapes, and the children's teeth are set on edge.
> But every one shall die for his own sin; every man who eats sour grapes, his teeth shall be set on edge.
>
> (Jeremiah 31:29–30)

Individuals are responsible for their own actions: this is one of the earliest references in literature to individual responsibility. People are free to act in their own self-interests or in wider interests despite the group, but they have to take responsibility for their actions rather than putting that responsibility on the group. And although individual responsibility is significant, we find that Aristotle, amongst many others, is well aware of the influence of the group upon individual behaviour (see Nussbaum, 1986). Clearly, individual responsibility is important as we think about learning to be persons in society; the issue at this moment is the mere fact of and significance of the individual in the group. But the group is more significant to the individual than the Enlightenment allowed.

In order to prove existence, Descartes started with the individual – *I think, therefore I am*. In contrast, existentialists reverse this assertion since existence is assumed and never needs to be proven. This means that the Cartesian dictum is unnecessary – but this does not automatically exclude some form of dualist arguments about the relationship between the mind and the body. I am! But what does existence actually mean? I know I am, and I do not need to prove it to myself. Because I am, I think. Maquarrie (1973: 125) writes:

> But what does it mean to say, 'I am'? 'I am' is the same as 'I exist'; but 'I exist', in turn, is equivalent to 'I-am-in-the-world', or again 'I-am-with-others'. So the premise of the argument is not anything so abstract as 'I think' or even 'I am' if it is understood in some isolated sense. The premise is the immediately rich and complex reality, 'I-am-with-others-in the world'.

But Bergson (1998 [1911]: 7) makes another vitally important point:

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> for a conscious being to exist is to change, to change is to mature, to mature is to go on creating oneself endlessly.

Existence, then, is never unchanging and for human beings it is always social; we live and move and have our being in a social context. We will argue throughout this volume that learning is the driving force of human change through which the human essence emerges and is nurtured. But, also, 'I-am-in-the-world' and 'I-am-with-others' are different phenomena: in the former, we are in the wider world but the latter can refer to our life-world (see Luckmann, 1983; Habermas, 1987; Williamson, 1998). But we know that we are in the world because we act, as MacMurray (1979 [1961]: 17) argued, 'We know existence by participating in existence', or, as Husserl said, 'I live *in* my Acts' (cited in Schutz, 1972: 51). I am, therefore I act, but also I act, therefore I am. But action is rarely meaningless, so that underlying action is intention and meaning but, paradoxically we have to learn meaning.

Social living is not only doing: it is meeting. Buber (1958: 17) wrote that 'all real living is meeting'. He goes on to conclude that this meeting is a present phenomenon between *I* and *Thou*. But he (ibid.: 22) goes even further to claim that, 'In the beginning is relationship', and it is 'through the *Thou* that the man becomes *I*'. The significance of the other is clearly seen in child psychology, in which we learn that the baby's brain grows and develops after birth. Gerhardt (2004: 43) explains the significance of the relationship to this process:

> Lots of positive experiences early on produce brains with more neural connections – more richly networked brains. We have all our neurons at birth, and we don't need to grow any more, but what we do need is to connect them up and make them work for us. With more connections, there is better performance and more ability to use particular areas of the brain.

Without the group, there can be no person. It is not that we live in society but that we are part of society – we are a part of society by class, age, gender, occupation and so on. It is we who are born in society and we become ourselves as a result of social living, and through our social living we contribute to the growth and development of other persons. This intrinsic connection between the person and the group, in which each member is bonded to some extent or another with other members of the group, is one of the main reasons for the paradox of the individual in the group, to which we will return later. Although the group is intrinsic to our growth, once we are grown then we assume our own individual responsibility and can decide whether we wish to continue to play our role in the group or whether, for one reason or another, we wish to step outside of it.

However, the fact that the person is always part of society/group/family does not end the study of locating the person in society since we have become more aware that in this globalised world each society is part of a larger entity – humanity itself. Humanity has a long history as palaeontologists and evolutionary psychologists, amongst others, have demonstrated to us. Humanity has evolved and as part of that evolution we have changed and developed to become the human beings that we now are. And so, we could depict the place of the ego in the wider society as in Figure 1.1. The upward arrows depict the process of time through which we have evolved, and in this sense we can now begin to locate one of the major contemporary debates – to what extent has humankind evolved so as to change the nature of culture? Do individuals have built into their brains (hard-wired) all the results of evolution so that the part that culture and learning play is significantly less than we originally thought? Clearly, this is the beginning of a long and drawn-out debate that I do not want to explore in depth here, although to fail to discuss it even briefly would do a disservice to our quest in this study. At the same time, not to recognise its significance also does a disservice.

Haslam (2007: 89–94) provides a clear introduction to the discussion when he suggests that both neurobiology and behavioural genetics offer important perspectives upon personality: 'neurobiology tells us about the brain processes that

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give rise to behaviour and its variations, and behavioural genetics tells us about the inherited structures that give rise to these brain processes' (ibid.: 89–90). Evolution is the natural process that operates on the genetic variation. Haslam (ibid.: 90) makes the point that 'evolution works in a slow, blind, and trial-and-error manner to improve the "design" of the biological species, ensuring that its genes underpin an array of functional adaptations'. At the same time, while the evolutionary process is not producing a standardised species, cultural differences into which we are socialised highlight the differences in us as persons: Haslam (ibid.: 94) suggests that 'most of the non-genetic contributions to personality are due to "non-shared environment": influences that are distinctive to individuals rather than shared within families'. Blakemore and Frith (2005: 186–7) show that, when we learn, our individual brains change and that this plasticity is not limited to childhood. Once we accept that the brain changes, it is possible to suggest the possibility of genetic change in the individual learner, which can then be transmitted to the next generation, but such genetic changes have not yet been demonstrated. In this sense, we can see that human learning still finds an important place within the wider spectrum of study which is beginning to be called 'the science of learning'.

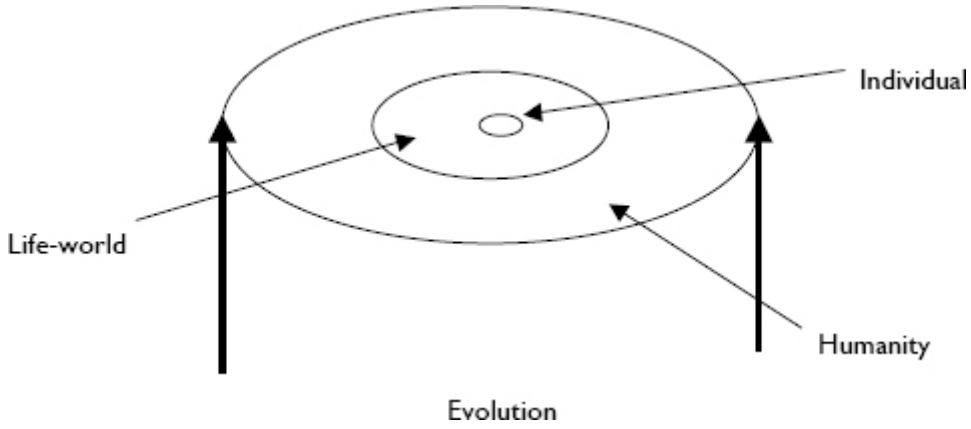


Figure 1.1 The social individual within humankind.

From the outset, it is important to note that few, if any, scholars would deny that evolution has occurred, but few have tried to explain it as fully as Dawkins (1976, 2006) has (see also Dennett, 1995, 2006). Dawkins would argue that evolution has played an extremely large part, and in order to summarise this position I am using Blackmore (2007) as one reference to Dawkins, but see also Dawkins (2006: 222–34). Following Dawkins, she starts by pointing out that fundamental to all human evolution is a process of imitation in which information is copied with variation and selection and that this is what Dawkins (1976) calls the 'replicator'. We shall return to imitative learning as fundamental to human growth and development below. For Dawkins the most familiar replicator is the gene, which survives as other bodies die in the process of time. The fact that the genes that successfully copy and survive have succeeded so that they will be copied and proliferate is why they are called 'selfish' by Dawkins. However, he wanted to break away from the idea of genes and so he called them 'memes' – 'units of cultural inheritance' (ibid.: 222), which he (ibid.: 92) suggested included 'tunes, ideas, catch-phrases, clothes, fashions, ways of making pots or building arches'. The literal meaning of meme is 'that which is imitated', and we will see in the work of Tomasello (1999) a totally different and, I believe, a more realistic approach to mimesis, or mimetics. Memes, if they exist, are what are copied, whereas what we learn by ourselves are not memes – nor are any of our primary experiences. Conceptually memes are at the heart of some theories of the evolutionary process and are its driving force because the learning that is built into the meme is now part of the evolutionary process – it is part of our hard-wiring. Blackmore (2007: 12) summarises this position:

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> This is really a general argument about the design of human nature. Whichever direction memetic evolution happened to take in the past, we humans would become better able to copy the memes that were successful – whether those words, music, paintings, rituals or anything else. Our modern brains therefore carry the traces of our past memetic evolution.

Evolution is clearly basic to our thinking, but the problem lies in the extent to which hard-wiring occurs and whether there is evidence for the existence of memes – and if not we need to understand more about the processes of hard-wiring. Fundamentally, memetics is a reductionist theory that needs a lot more hard scientific research to prove its point, and so this study turns to the manner in which Tomasello deals with imitation. Significantly, Blakemore and Frith (2005), while recognising the significance of genes to learning, make no mention of memes in their study of the learning brain. Nelson (2007: 44) also makes the point that no genes have been identified that influence human behaviour and also points out that genetic behaviourists separate the gene from the environment in a manner that does not lead to a clear understanding of human development. The similarity between memetics and mimesis is that they both point to a fundamental understanding of imitation although they have different ways of viewing it. Theorists of early childhood learning, then, start with imitation. Children imitate from birth and Tomasello (1999: 52) regards children between the ages of one and three years as 'imitation machines'. This imitation occurs in the intimate relationships that occur in the early life of a child; Tomasello (ibid.: 55) does not reject an evolutionary perspective but he wants to produce a dual perspective on human development:

> We have at most only 6 million years, but much more likely only one-quarter of a million years, to create uniquely human cognition, and this is simply not sufficient, under any plausible evolutionary scenario, for genetic variation and natural selection to have created many and different uniquely human cognitive modules.

He (p. 54) does accept that many of the skills possessed by all the primates, including human beings, are the result of the evolutionary processes. Other scholars, such as Donald (2001), reach similar conclusions, although Blackmore (2007: 7), wrongly and without evidence in my opinion, accuses Donald of rejecting the whole of the argument out of fear. Tomasello's dual position is attractive since it allows us both to accept the validity of the evolutionary argument but also to recognise that evolution is a slower process than that of individual learning – even imitative learning – and so culture also plays a dominant part in human development.

Conclusion

From the above discussion, we can see that each of the major terms is contentious and we have laid the foundations here to understand what it means to learn to become persons in society. All of the major concepts are inter-related and intertwined, yet there are fundamental differences about the place of culture and therefore learning in the process of becoming human persons. We have briefly reviewed this debate, although the relationship between evolution and learning calls for a more in-depth study. Whereas imitation is at the heart of this process, the memetic theory appears reductionist and speculative – more speculative than the theories it tries to replace. We are now, therefore, in a better position to explore a basic theory of human learning.

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